Sustainable Performance - Study guide

Foundation course | Trainer: Grace Whitfield

About this guide

Practical habits for energy, focus and recovery during demanding seasons of work.

These notes follow the video lecture for this course. Read them before or after watching, and use them to revise before the final quiz.

What you will be able to do

- Plan your week around energy, not just time

- Set boundaries you can keep

- Notice early signs of overload

Performance depends on recovery

- Effort without recovery does not last

- Energy is the real resource

- Sustainable beats heroic

Welcome to Sustainable Performance. Many people believe that doing well means working longer. In practice, output depends on energy as much as on hours. Effort without recovery works for a short sprint, but it wears people down over months. This lecture is about doing good work in a way you can keep up. We will cover how to plan around energy, how to set boundaries you can keep, how to notice overload early, and how to build small recovery habits into an ordinary week.

Energy is the real resource

- Time is fixed, energy is not

- Notice when you do your best thinking

- Protect that time for important work

You cannot add hours to the day, but you can change how much energy you bring to them. Most people have a pattern. Some think best early, others in the afternoon. Spend a week noticing when your focus is sharpest and when it dips. Then protect your best hours for work that needs real thought, and use the low-energy times for routine tasks

like admin and email. Planning your week around energy, not just time, often gets more done in fewer hours, and leaves you less drained at the end of the day.

Four kinds of energy

- Physical: sleep, movement, food

- Emotional: how you feel

- Mental: focus and attention

- Purpose: why the work matters

It helps to think of energy in four kinds. Physical energy comes from sleep, movement and food, and it underpins everything else. Emotional energy is how you feel, which is affected by relationships and by stress. Mental energy is focus, and it is drained by constant switching between tasks. Purpose energy comes from knowing why your work matters. When you feel flat, ask which of the four is low. The answer points to a different fix each time. A short walk helps physical energy, while a clearer goal helps purpose.

Boundaries you can keep

- A boundary is a clear, kind limit

- Offer an alternative where you can

- Start with one you can actually hold

A boundary is a clear, kind limit on what you will do and when. It is not a refusal to help. A healthy boundary often sounds like, I can do that on Thursday, or, I can do the first half today. Offering an alternative keeps the relationship positive. The common mistake is setting a boundary so ambitious that you break it within days, which teaches you to ignore your own limits. Start with one that you can actually hold, such as not checking messages after a set time, and build from there.

Recognising overload early

- Trouble switching off

- Irritability and cynicism

- Small tasks feel heavy

Overload builds slowly, so the early signs are easy to miss. Watch for trouble switching off in the evening, a shorter temper, a growing cynicism about work, or small tasks that suddenly feel heavy. Changes in sleep and appetite are also common signals. The key is to notice the trend, not a single bad day. If you see several signs for more than a couple of weeks, treat it as information and act. Talk to someone, reduce a commitment, or ask for support. Waiting until you are exhausted makes recovery much longer.

Small recovery habits

- Short breaks between demanding tasks

- A real end to the working day

- One thing each week that restores you

Recovery does not have to mean a holiday. Short breaks between demanding tasks let your attention reset. A clear end to the working day, such as closing the laptop and taking a short walk, helps your mind switch off. And one thing each week that genuinely restores you, whether that is exercise, time with friends, or a hobby, gives you something to look forward to. These habits are small, but they add up. The key is to schedule them like meetings, because if they are optional, they are the first thing to go.

Talking about workload

- Be specific about what is on your plate

- Ask what can wait

- Raise it early, with options

If your workload is too high, saying so early is a strength, not a weakness. Be specific. Instead of saying you are overwhelmed, list what is on your plate and what each item needs. Ask your manager or colleague what can wait or be dropped. Bring options rather than only a problem, such as moving a deadline or sharing a task. Most managers prefer to hear about pressure when there is still room to adjust. Keeping

quiet until something breaks is harder for everyone, including you.

Your next steps

- Track your energy for one week

- Choose one boundary to hold

- Complete the workbook and the final quiz

To finish, track your energy levels for one week, noting when you feel sharp and when you feel flat. Choose one boundary that you will hold, and tell someone about it. Complete the workbook for this course, which includes an energy log and a weekly planning page. Then take the final quiz. When you reach the end of the last lesson you will receive your certificate and a personal review of how you worked through the course. Sustainable performance is built from small, steady habits, so be patient and keep going.

Glossary

Energy: The capacity you bring to work: physical, emotional, mental and purpose-related.

Boundary: A clear, kind limit on what you will do and when.

Overload: A sustained state where demands exceed your capacity to recover.

Recovery: Activities that restore energy, from short breaks to rest days.